

ECO-TOURISM DESTINATIONS

Sohelwa Forest Region, Shravasti

1. Sonpathari Ashram

Sonpathari Ashram is located near Sonpathari Naka, approximately 8 km inside the former Sohelwa Forest Area, close to the India-Nepal border.

The Ashram was established around 60 years ago by Swami Siddhanath (Sanyasi Maharaj) for spiritual meditation and devotion. Surrounded by forests, mountain streams and scenic landscapes, the place attracts tourists as well as devotees.

Devotees visit the Ashram throughout the year. The traditional ****Bhandara**** initiated by Swamiji has been continuing for nearly 60 years.

As the Ashram is situated within a protected forest area, regulated tourist activities and controlled visitor movement can contribute to forest and wildlife conservation while also supporting departmental revenue generation.

2. Vibhutinath (Gupt Kashi) Temple

Vibhutinath, popularly known as ****Gupt Kashi****, is an ancient Shiva temple. According to local belief, the temple was discovered by the Pandavas during their period of exile.

It is also believed that during the reign of Aurangzeb, an attempt was made to break the Shiva Lingam. According to the local tradition, blood emerged from the Shiva Lingam when it was struck, after which the soldiers stopped their attempt.

The temple attracts devotees who come to perform traditional worship and rituals. Large gatherings are organised during ****Shravan, Mahashivratri and Kajri Teej****, when thousands of devotees and tourists visit the site.

3. Rajiyatal

Rajiyatal is a natural water source located inside the forest area near Vibhutinath Temple.

According to local belief, the water source was developed during the period of Rajiya Sultan. The natural surroundings of Rajiyatal are highly scenic and attractive.

A permanent watchtower has been constructed on the bank of the water body for visitors. From its elevated position, tourists can enjoy panoramic views of the surrounding dense forest and water body.

During the month of Shravan, devotees collect water from Rajiyatal and use it for ****Jalabhishek**** at the ancient Shiva Lingam at Gupt Kashi.

4. Wanghogha Reservoir

Wanghogha Reservoir, situated in the former Sohelwa Forest Area, is an attractive natural destination because of its tranquil water body, dense forests and rich natural biodiversity.

During winter, visitors can observe a variety of ****migratory and resident birds****, making the area suitable for birdwatching and nature photography.

The surrounding greenery, natural wildlife activities, and beautiful sunrise and sunset views provide visitors with a memorable experience of nature.

5. Hilly Streams and Nature Trails

The ****Sonpathari Hilly Stream****, located within the forest area, is known for its naturally flowing water, dense Sal forests, green valleys and natural trekking trails.

The area becomes particularly attractive during the ****monsoon and winter seasons****. Nature lovers, trekkers and photographers can enjoy its scenic beauty and peaceful surroundings.

The calm environment, melodious calls of birds and natural presence of wildlife make this area highly promising from an ****eco-tourism perspective****.

6. Tharu Tribal Culture and Rural Life Experience

The Tharu community residing near the former Sohelwa Forest Area is known for its distinctive traditional culture, folk dances, traditional attire and nature-based lifestyle.

Visitors can experience the local rural environment, traditional cuisine, handicrafts and cultural programmes.

The development of eco-tourism in this area can provide an attractive platform for ****cultural tourism and community participation****, while creating opportunities for local communities.

7. Rampur Reservoir

Rampur Reservoir is an attractive natural wetland situated in the former Sohelwa Forest Area and surrounded by dense forests and rich natural biodiversity.

During winter, the presence of various ****migratory and resident birds**** makes the reservoir particularly attractive to tourists.

The peaceful surroundings, greenery along the reservoir, and natural activities of wildlife make it suitable for ****birdwatching, nature photography and eco-tourism****.

The reservoir also offers beautiful natural views during sunrise and sunset, providing visitors with a memorable experience.

8. Bhainsahi Naka

Bhainsahi Naka, located near the ****India-Nepal border****, presents a unique combination of natural beauty, forest landscapes and the cultural environment of the border region.

The surrounding dense forests, natural streams and lush Terai landscape attract visitors.

The area provides an opportunity to experience the natural environment, observe wildlife and explore the

rural and cultural life of the border region.

Its peaceful and clean surroundings offer visitors a distinctive nature-based experience close to the India-Nepal border.